

U.S. Deportation and the Limits of DGICM



Countries discussing during DGICM's unmoderated caucus (AP Photo)

DGICM (AP) — Countries in the ASEAN Directors-General of Immigration and Heads and Consular Affairs (DGICM) are currently tackling the challenge of irregular immigration. ASEAN holds a high demographic of irregular migrants, which poses a prevalent issue.

DGICM, established in 1996 by ASEAN, acts as a platform for the chiefs of immigration agencies in ASEAN to discuss regional issues on immigration and consulate matters. It has played an instrumental role for ASEAN, by establishing policies, hence endorsing collaborations with members of ASEAN. The foundation of DGICM is built on regional cooperation within ASEAN and human migration rights.

Concerns regarding ICE

In light of recent investigations, U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) have been revealed to be carrying out a rapidly expanding, multibillion-dollar mass deportation.

Reports highlight significant concerns regarding detainee medical neglect, misconduct risks tied to rapid hiring sprees, and the withholding of arrest records. In 33 states, detainees reported dangerous delays or outright denials of medication for severe conditions like HIV, diabetes, and epilepsy in ICE facilities. Furthermore, emergency calls from ICE detention camps detail critical medical crises, malnutrition, and suicide attempts.²⁰

In the past year alone, ICE had doubled its workforce to 22,000 in under a year. The rapid expansion—coupled with the hiring of some employees without completed background checks or with past force-abuse lawsuits—has prompted concerns among former law enforcement officials about potential corruption and misconduct.²¹

According to recent records, ICE leadership has instructed officers that judicial warrants are no longer needed to forcibly enter homes to arrest deportees, which critics argue undermines Fourth Amendment protections. States and local partners in states like Florida have had records and body camera footage arrested from public disclosure.²²

²⁰ Bichell, Rae Ellen, Claire Galofaro, Maia Rosenfeld, Renuka Rayasam, Aaron M Kessler, Byron Tau, Associated Press, and Kff Health News. “Takeaways from AP-KFF Investigation into Allegations of Medical Neglect in ICE Detention.” AP News, June 2, 2026.
<https://apnews.com/article/ice-detention-medical-neglect-takeaways-f3c6d9d0ac3332dca0419e543db6e955>.

²¹ Foley, Ryan J. “Takeaways from AP’s Review of Criminal Charges against ICE Personnel.” AP News, February 11, 2026.
<https://apnews.com/article/ice-agents-arrested-misconduct-abuse-corruption-charged-d3aeb8c20191fa357f87078fc169cc17>.

²² Salomon, Gisela. “Florida Agencies Partner with ICE to Help Trump’s Immigration Crackdown.” AP News, June 11, 2026.
<https://apnews.com/article/florida-ice-trump-immigration-crackdown-c0dc423b1df8d6710328f9e92e0cccbc>.

Backed by over \$170 billion in funding, ICE is purchasing warehouses to double detention capacity, targeting the removal of 1 million people per fiscal year.²³

U.S. take on irregular migration



U.S. speaking about the issue of irregular migration (AP Photo)

²³ Santana, Rebecca. "Trump Recalibrates Immigration Crackdown with Quieter Strategy." AP News, May 2026.
<https://apnews.com/article/immigration-ice-border-trump-mass-deportations-77ca6741fe11ac35852c8b15d3016991>.

In a press conference with President Donald Trump, mass deportation is framed as a sovereign right and security necessity.²⁴ However, the International Labour Organisation (ILO) calls for states to address vulnerabilities for irregular migrants, including removal.

The U.S, in response to this concern, stated that ICE has the authority to deport undocumented migrants. With the current concern of the influx of irregular migrants into the country, the U.S. will hardline on the issue of irregular migration, which leads to deportation.

The Stakes for ASEAN

ASEAN member states send significant migrant worker populations to the US, some of which may be in irregular situations. ICE practices have direct implications for their nationals which is a concern for DGICM: the widening gap between the pace of U.S. enforcement and the current procedural safeguards. This is a threat of the human and labour rights frameworks that ASEAN seeks to uphold for its migrant workers abroad.

Currently, organisations such as the ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights (APHR) have already flagged escalations in ICE enforcement. This includes detaining Southeast Asia immigrants, particularly from Cambodia, Laos and Vietnam.²⁵

Deportations need to be ensured as necessary and also responsibly carried out. DGIM is urged to address this in the implementation of their Irregular Migration policies with U.S. cooperation. Where immigrant rights are being emphasised in this committee, members will continue to discuss and come to a consensus.

²⁴ Matthey, Nicci. "Mass Deportation in the U.S.: Explainer." National Immigration Forum, January 23, 2025. <https://forumtogether.org/article/mass-deportation-in-the-u-s-explainer/>.

²⁵ Aseanmp.org. "APHR Calls for the Safety and Rights of Southeast Asian Immigrants amid ICE Crackdown in the US - APHR," 2025. <https://aseanmp.org/publications/post/aphr-calls-for-the-safety-and-rights-of-southeast-asian-immigrants-amid-ice-crackdown-in-the-us>.

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